

Christmas Easter Observance

prc-christmas-easter-observance

Calendar & Customs · Holy Days · practice · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

Supported across many Bible texts

Reached by general principle, not by a naming word

Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

The observance of Christmas and Easter (Resurrection Sunday) is a matter of Christian liberty (Romans 14:5-6); the Christian calendar is not commanded in the New Testament but neither is its observance forbidden.

In plain language

The words in the two anchor passages do not name Christmas or Easter at all. In Romans 14:5 Paul uses 'judge' or 'esteem' (krino) for someone who rates one day above another, and 'be fully convinced' (plerophoreo), telling each person to settle the matter in his own mind (idios nous). In 14:6 both the one who keeps the day and the one who does not are said to act 'to the Lord' (kurio), and to 'give thanks to God' (eucharistei to theo). That language frames the day question as personal conviction held before God, which is the textual root of a liberty reading (treating it as a free matter of conscience). In Colossians 2:16 Paul says let no one judge you over a feast, a new moon, or sabbaths, and in 2:17 he calls these a shadow of things to come whose body belongs to Christ. The three words there, 'feast' (heorte), 'new moon' (noumenia), and 'sabbath' (sabbaton), are the standard Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint) terms for the Jewish festal calendar, and 'new moon' (noumenia) in fact appears nowhere else in the New Testament (it is a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament), which fixes its sense entirely from the old covenant cult. So the text closes the old required calendar but says nothing about any later Christian holiday. The complication is Galatians 4:10, where Paul rebukes people who observe days and months and seasons and years, and shows alarm in 4:11. The same Greek word 'observe' (paratereo) elsewhere in the canon describes hostile watching, and Paul links the calendar there to weak 'elemental principles' (stoicheia). On the bare words alone a reader can build a case that uncommanded days are a free matter held before the Lord, and another reader can build a case that observing days the New Testament never commands is exactly what Paul warns against. The lexicon supplies two patterns and does not rank them. Because the specific holidays in the proposition are never named in the canon, the precise claim is left unsettled by the text itself. The verdict is recorded as disputed for that reason. The underlying vocabulary about days and conviction is clear, but its application to the Christian calendar is an inference the words neither make nor close.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G1035	βρῶσις	brōsis	eating	
G1859	ἑορτή	heorte	festival	26
G2168	εὐχαριστέω	eucharisteo	to thank	38
G2250	ἡμέρα	hemera	day	392
G2919	κρίνω	krino	to judge	115

G3195	μέλλω	mello	to ensue	111
G3313	μέρος	meros	part	
G3561	νουμηνία	noumenia	New Moon	1
G3563	νοῦς	nous	mind	24
G3906	παρατηρέω	paratereo	to observe	6
G4135	πληροφορέω	plerophoreo	to fulfill	6
G4213	πόσις	posis	drink	
G4521	σάββατον	sabbaton	Sabbath	68
G4639	σκιά	skia	shadow	7
G4983	σῶμα	soma	body	144
G5426	φρονέω	phroneo	to reason	30

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

Romans 14:5 sets the phrase 'judges one day above another' (krinei hemeran par hemeran) against 'judges every day alike' (krinei pasan hemeran), and settles the dispute by 'let each be fully convinced in his own mind' (hekastos en to idio noi plerophoreistho), with both parties acting 'to the Lord' (kurio) and giving thanks 'to God' (eucharisto to theo) in 14:6. That grammar lexically authorises a reading of liberty (freedom of personal conviction). Colossians 2:16 forbids judging 'in part of a feast or new moon or sabbaths' (en merei heortes e noumenias e sabbaton), exactly the triad of festival, new moon, and sabbath that is the technical Mosaic calendar in the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint), and 2:17 classes them as 'a shadow of the things to come' (skia ton mellonton), whose 'body' or 'substance' (soma) belongs to Christ. Neither passage names Christmas or Easter; the canon never mentions them. Galatians 4:10 rebukes 'you observe days and months and seasons and years' (hemeras paratereisthe kai menas kai kairous kai eniautous) as a return to weak 'elemental principles' (stoicheia), so the same vocabulary about observing days can be censured. The lexicon therefore yields two unranked patterns. A liberty pattern from Romans 14 and a censure pattern from Galatians 4. The specific application to a post-canonical Christian calendar (one developed after the New Testament closed) is an inference the words neither make nor close.

Scripture

Rom.14.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2919 κρίνω, G2250 ἡμέρα, G4135 πληροφορέω, G3563 νοῦς

Reasoning. The phrase 'judges one day beyond another' (krinei hemeran par hemeran) is set against 'judges every day alike' (krinei pasan hemeran). The resolution is not a command for or against observance but 'let each be fully convinced in his own mind' (hekastos en to idio noi plerophoreistho). The lexical weight falls on 'one's own mind' (idios nous), meaning personal conviction, and on 'be fully assured' (plerophoreo). That is the textual root of the liberty reading (the reading that treats this as a free matter of personal conviction).

Rom.14.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5426 φρονέω, G2168 εὐχαριστέω, G2250 ἡμέρα

Reasoning. 'The one who minds the day minds it to the Lord' (ho phronon ten hemeran kyrio phronei) parallels 'the one who eats does so to the Lord, for he gives thanks to God' (ho esthion kyrio esthiei, eucharistei gar to theo). The verse frames opposing practices as alike God-directed and bracketed by thanksgiving, which supports a liberty reading where the matter is held 'before God' (coram Deo) rather than legislated for the body.

Col.2.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2919 κρίνω, G1859 ἑορτή, G3561 νουμηνία, G4521 σάββατον

Reasoning. 'Let no one therefore judge you' (me oun tis hymas krineto) governs 'in food and drink' (en brosei kai en posei), then a festal triad (a three-part festival list), 'in respect of a feast or new moon or sabbaths' (en merei heortes e noumenias e sabbaton). The triad of 'feast' (heorte), 'new moon' (noumenia), and 'sabbath' (sabbaton) matches the recurring Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint) cultic formula for the Mosaic calendar (compare 1 Chronicles 23:31, 2 Chronicles 2:4, 2 Chronicles 31:3, Hosea 2:11, Ezekiel 45:17). 'New moon' (noumenia) is a true New Testament hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament), occurring only here, and its sense is anchored entirely by that Septuagint background. The technical referent is the old covenant calendar, not the later Christian one, which the canon never names.

Col.2.17 · neutral · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4639 σκιά, G4983 σῶμα, G3195 μέλλω

Reasoning. 'Which are a shadow of the coming things' (ha estin skia ton mellonton), 'but the body is of Christ' (to de soma tou Christou). The same contrast between 'shadow' (skia) and 'body' or 'substance' (soma) recurs in Hebrews 8:5 and Hebrews 10:1 for the tabernacle and the law respectively, which fixes the sense: the named days are a typological forecast (an Old Testament pattern that points forward to a New Testament reality) already fulfilled. The verse closes the old calendar as binding but says nothing about days the New Testament neither names nor commands.

Gal.4.10 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2250 ἡμέρα, G3906 παρατηρέω

Reasoning. 'You observe days and months and seasons and years' (hemeras paratereisthe kai menas kai kairous kai eniautous). 'Observe' (paratereo) in the middle voice (a Greek verb form indicating the subject acts upon or for themselves) in Galatians, with Paul's alarm in 4:11 ('I am afraid for you,' phoboumai hymas), names calendar observance as a return to 'the weak and beggarly elemental principles' (ta asthene kai ptocha stoicheia) in 4:9. The same verb 'observe' (paratereo) elsewhere in the canon (Mark 3:2, Luke 6:7, Luke 14:1, Luke 20:20, Acts 9:24) describes hostile or scheming watching, which colours the rebuke. This supplies the lexical ground for a regulative reading (the reading that worship may only include what Scripture commands) that cuts against an unqualified liberty verdict.

Heb.10.1 · neutral · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4639 σκιά, G3195 μέλλω

Reasoning. 'For the law has a shadow of the good things to come' (skian gar echon ho nomos ton mellonton agathon). The same lexical pairing as Colossians 2:17, that is 'shadow' (skia) plus 'about to come' (mello), fixes the referent of the Colossians triad to the Mosaic typological system (the Old Testament pattern of forecasts that point to Christ). This is the canon-internal lexical cross-check that the festal language in Colossians 2:16 is about the old calendar.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Col.2.16	Lev.23.1	tsk	1
Col.2.16	Lev.16.31	tsk	1
Col.2.16	Num.10.10	tsk	1
Col.2.16	Lev.11.2	tsk	1
Rom.14.6	Exod.12.14	tsk	1
Col.2.17	Heb.10.1	openbible	1

Complicating texts

Gal.4.10 · addressed

Galatians 4:10 censures observing 'days and months and seasons and years' (hemeras kai menas kai kairous kai eniautous) and supplies a lexical ground for treating calendar observance as transgression. The text-internal resolution is that in Galatians the days are bound to 'the elemental principles of the world' (ta stoicheia tou kosmou) in 4:3 and 4:9, and to a works-righteous return to bondage, while Romans 14 frames day-esteeming as personal conviction held 'to the Lord' (kurio) with thanksgiving. The two passages pull in opposite directions on the bare lexicon, which is why the verdict is disputed rather than affirmed. The vocabulary does not rank the two patterns.

Col.2.16 · addressed

The triad of 'feast' (heorte), 'new moon' (noumenia), and 'sabbath' (sabbaton) is the technical Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint) Mosaic festal vocabulary, and 'new moon' (noumenia) is a New Testament hapax legomenon (a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament) attested only here, so its sense is fixed entirely by Old Testament cultic legislation. The verse therefore removes any binding obligation to keep the old calendar but neither authorises nor prohibits a later post-canonical Christian calendar (one developed after the New Testament closed), which the lexicon does not name. The specific proposition is left underdetermined by the words.

Concordance traversed

G2250, G2919, G4135, G3563, G5426, G2168, G1859, G3561, G4521, G4639, G4983, G3906, G3195, G1035, G4213, G3313

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

rom-14-6-kai-ho-me-phronon at Rom.14.6: impact none. Some witnesses add 'and the one who does not observe the day does not observe to the Lord' (kai ho me phronon ten hemeran kyrio ou phronei). The addition reinforces the symmetry of observance and non-observance and does not alter the liberty-versus-regulative balance.

col-2-16-e-en-merei at Col.2.16: impact none. Minor connective variation between 'or' (e) and 'and' (kai) inside the festal list does not change the referent, the Mosaic calendar triad, nor the verdict.

Both anchor passages lie outside the open-cbqm 3 John sample (the test set for the Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a computer-assisted way of weighing manuscript witnesses), so CBGM was not run. The variants examined are editorial-apparatus level (drawn from standard critical editions of the Greek New Testament) and do not touch the verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. redemptive-historical

Frameworks in play. liberty_of_conscience, regulative_principle, shadow_fulfillment, covenant_theology, dispensationalism, new_covenant_theology

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

liberty_of_conscience: affirms · Romans 14:5-6 leaves day-esteeming to 'one's own mind' (idios nous), meaning personal conviction, with both observance and non-observance referred 'to the Lord' (kurio) and bracketed by 'he gives thanks to God' (eucharistei to theo). A day the New Testament neither commands nor forbids therefore falls under this same liberty, and commemoration of the incarnation or resurrection by those persuaded to do so is licit (allowed) so long as it is not imposed.

regulative_principle: denies · Worship elements not commanded by Scripture are excluded. Galatians 4:10 names 'observing' (paratero) of 'days and months and seasons and years' (hemeras kai menas kai kairous kai eniautous) as a return to 'elemental principles' (stoicheia), and Colossians 2:17 abolishes the festal shadow without instituting

a replacement. On this reading an uncommanded Christian calendar is not a free matter in corporate worship but disallowed by silence, since the New Testament prescribes the Lord's day and the Lord's Supper and no annual feasts.

shadow_fulfillment: neutral · Colossians 2:17 classes the Mosaic festal triad as 'a shadow of the coming things' (skia ton mellonton) whose 'body' (soma) is Christ, and Hebrews 10:1 uses the same pairing of 'shadow' (skia) plus 'about to come' (mello) for the whole law. This abolishes the old calendar without naming or settling any later one, so the lexicon as such leaves the post-canonical question (the question about practices developed after the New Testament closed) undecided.

pagan_origins_objection: denies · The lexicon does not contain Christmas or Easter, so this lens cannot be settled by the words alone. Read on its strongest lexical footing it appeals to the regulative pull of Galatians 4:10 against syncretism (the mixing of pagan religious practice with Christian worship) with the calendar of the surrounding culture, by analogy with the deuteronomic warnings against the religious customs of the nations. The analogy is extracanonical reasoning (argument that goes beyond what the words of Scripture themselves say), but the underlying lexical worry, that days bound up with the wrong devotion can become a snare, is in the text.

The verdict turns on whether a day neither commanded nor forbidden falls under Romans 14 liberty or under the regulative exclusion implied by Galatians 4:10. The lexicon supports both readings, and 'the analogy of Scripture' (analogia scripturae, the principle of interpreting Scripture by Scripture) does not collapse the question to a single verdict because the shadow-fulfillment line resolves only the old calendar.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Does the New Testament treat the esteeming of particular days, where a day is neither commanded nor forbidden, as a matter left to individual conviction, or does it restrict observance to what is commanded?

The phrases 'matter of Christian liberty' and 'not commanded but neither forbidden' encode the 'things indifferent' (adiaphora, a category of practices Scripture neither commands nor forbids) conclusion that the liberty side of the dispute reaches. The regulative reading would deny that an uncommanded day is a free matter. The verdict is derived on the original stem, but the audit records that the stem leans toward the liberty side before the evidence is weighed.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.14.5
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Col.2.16
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Gal.4.10
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2919
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1859
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3561
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4639
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3906
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4135
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Col.2.16
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Col.2.17
interlinear	Nestle1904-text	public_domain	yes	Col.2.17

License audit

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MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
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TSK	public_domain	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes
Nestle1904-text	public_domain	yes

Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · cross-tradition-divergent